ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour

Edited by
Zafar Abbas Juma

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Knowing about God is not knowing Him

On a day of fasting in Ramadan, by late afternoon, no one has to be told that they are hungry. They do not read it in a book or work it out from the clock. The hunger is known from the inside. Sheikh Bahmanpour uses hunger to describe a kind of knowing that study cannot give.

Most of what we know of God is of the kind gained by study. We learn the rulings of fiqh, the beliefs the scholars set out, and the history of the Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (as). All of it is knowledge about God. The Qur'an's invitation to more than the minimum is an invitation to knowing God like a fasting person knows hunger: intimately and undoubtedly. This chapter defines the difference between knowing God and knowing about God, and then explores how He comes to be known.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *ʿIlm*: knowledge, especially knowledge gained by study · *ʿilm al-husuli*: acquired knowledge · *ʿilm al-huduri*: knowledge by presence · *ʿaql*: the reasoning intellect · *suluk*: wayfaring; the path of purification

Knowing about, and knowing

Let's start with the two kinds of knowing. The first is acquired knowledge (*ʿilm al-husuli*). It reaches us from outside, through the senses or by reasoning.

We form concepts of the things around us and then analyse those concepts. Almost everything we learn from teachers and books is of this kind, including what we know about God.

Acquired knowledge works by defining its object. To understand a thing, we sort it into a category and mark where it ends and something else begins. The Arabic word for a definition (*hadd*) also means a limit: to define a thing is to limit it. The old definition of a human being as "the rational animal" works by drawing a line around us.

The second kind is knowledge by presence (*'ilm al-huduri*). It does not come from outside and needs no concept to be understood; it is already with the soul. The clearest case of knowledge by presence is knowing that we exist. Nobody teaches us that, we don't reason our way to it, and we can't be wrong about it. We simply know it from the inside. Hunger, pain, and anxiety are further examples known in the same way. Each may have an external cause, but the feeling itself arises inside us.

Knowledge by presence is complete. When the body is hungry, the soul knows it at once and without effort, and nothing of the hunger is missed. The hunger may even be false, and yet what is felt is real. A person may be wrong to think that their body needs food. They cannot be wrong that they feel hungry.

Knowledge by presence is what the mystics are after. Sheikh Bahmanpour defines mysticism as the urge to reach out to the infinite through knowledge by presence. Acquired knowledge (*'ilm*) aims at understanding, whereas knowledge by presence (*ma'rifah*) aims at arriving. A person during the meal of iftar cannot understand hunger as sharply as they will understand it during the next day's fast, despite having spent most of their day hungry. There is no substitute for arriving in that moment. In this way, mystics seek to arrive at God.

Ayatullah Khomeini describes the scholar and the 'arif in distinct terms, with each earning their own label; the scholar is the one who acquires knowledge and thereby "attains the knowledge of God through philosophical proofs", whereas the 'arif is the one who gains knowledge through presence and so "knows God through direct witnessing"[1].

[1]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.

ع WORD STUDY: ʿILM AL-HUSULI AND ʿILM AL-HUDURI

Husul means acquiring or obtaining, whereas *hudur* means presence. In acquired knowledge (*ʿilm al-husuli*), what reaches the mind is a concept or an image of the thing, while the thing itself stays outside. In knowledge by presence (*ʿilm al-huduri*), the thing known is itself present to the soul, as our own self, our hunger, and our pain are present. The phrase Ayatullah Khomeini uses for the gnostic's witnessing, *mushahada huduriyya* (witnessing by presence), comes from the same root. Sheikh Bahmanpour notes that the religious texts use *ʿilm* and *maʿrifah* for the same thing, whereas Ayatullah Khomeini writes of "an evident difference" between *ʿirfan* and *ʿilm*[2]. This book keeps the two apart to make the two kinds of knowing easier to see. Chapter One's Word Study noted that there is no way to God except through knowledge, and left open what type of knowledge it refers to. If *maʿrifah* is arriving, as this chapter describes it, that knowledge is knowledge by presence.

Where reason stops

Acquired knowledge is the work of reason (*ʿaql*), the faculty by which we understand and argue. Reason has a limit. When we know a thing, we know its attributes: its colour, its size, and what it does. Every description says that it is brown, square, or useful, and none says what the "it" is. Ibn Sina, the master of philosophy, granted this. The reality of things, he held, is beyond the reach of human reason.

If reason cannot reach what the things around us are, it falls still further short of God, who has no colour or size for the mind to take hold of. Imam ʿAli (as) speaks of reason's limit at the opening of the first oration in *Nahj al-Balagha*, where he praises God.

لا يدركه بعد الهمم ولا يناله غوص الفطن

Soaring thoughts cannot reach him and deep minds cannot fathom him.[3]

Nahj al-Balagha

The two images can be read as reason at its widest range and reason at its deepest, and Imam ʿAli says that neither reaches God. The next sentence of

[2]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.

[3]Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.

the oration continues: God "cannot be described, for he is beyond the limits of demarcated boundaries"[4]. A definition draws a line round its object, and there is no line to draw round God.

Reason can still argue that God exists, and it can say what He is not: God cannot be an object, and He is not in one place and absent from another. All of this is knowledge about God. Apart from the proof that He exists, the rest is negative knowledge, in which each statement says what God is not, rather than saying what He is.

'Irfan asks for the positive side. We cannot know God's essence. What 'irfan seeks is His attributes, known positively: God as the Merciful, the Compassionate, and the Forgiving. The names can be learned from a book. To know God as Merciful from within, as a hungry person knows their hunger, is knowledge by presence. Mulla Sadra held that knowledge by presence is the only way to know the reality of anything, and the only way to know God. The comparison with hunger is an example of this knowledge's attainment and not its extent. As the Sheikh puts it frankly, "the more you know, the more bewildered you will become".

We have knowledge by presence only of what is within us: our own self and some of its states. A sense of God already lives there, however faint: a vague idea of God that we carry inside us. If God is to be known, and not only known about, the knowing must happen within the soul.

◈ WHO'S WHO: MULLA SADRA AND THE SCHOOLS OF PHILOSOPHY

Mulla Sadra died in 1050/1640[5]. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Islamic philosophy before him had two branches: the Peripatetic (*al-hikma al-mashsha'iyya*) and the Illuminationist. Mulla Sadra changed its course. He called his own philosophy neither of these but the transcendent philosophy (*al-hikma al-muta'aliya*). He claimed for it a rationalised mysticism, giving rational argument to what the mystics know only by experience. For Murtada Mutahhari, the philosopher works with "reason, deductions and proofs", whereas the 'arif works with "the heart and the purification, disciplining and perfecting of the self"[6]. Mulla Sadra studied the 'irfan of Ibn 'Arabi deeply without belonging

[4]Imam 'Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.
[5]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 40.
[6]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[7]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 35, 40.

to any Sufi order, and rated Ibn ʿArabi above Ibn Sina[7]. *Kernel of the Kernels* records that after a lifetime in philosophy he became absorbed in worship and the purification of his inner being. He asked God's pardon for the part of his life spent studying "the opinions of the pseudo-philosophers and polemicists from among the theologians", until "it became clear to me that their syllogisms were barren and their path devoid of straightness"[8].

Light in the heart

The limits of study alone are described in a hadith that Ayatullah Khomeini quotes in his *Forty Hadith*:

Knowledge is not extensive learning. Rather, it is a light that God casts in the heart of whomever He wills.[9]

Hadith

It is clear that God's light is needed to succeed in the pursuit of this kind of knowledge. However, the phrase "whomever He wills" highlights that the receiving of this light is not a foregone conclusion. The Verse of Light in Surah al-Nur adds Qur'anic weight to this sentiment:

ٱللَّهُ نُورُ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلۡأَرۡضِۚ

Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth.

Qur'an 24:35

يَهۡدِي ٱللَّهُ لِنُورِهِۦ مَن يَشَآءُۚ

Allah guides to His Light whomever He wishes.

Qur'an 24:35

How, then, does God choose whom He guides? The Sheikh's answer is that He chooses those He loves, and that the traveller therefore purifies the heart

[8] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 7.
[9] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

first, "in the hope that Allah will choose you". Surah al-Baqarah names where that purity begins.

وَٱتَّقُواْ ٱللَّهَ ۖ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ ٱللَّهُ ۗ

Be wary of Allah and Allah will teach you.

Qur'an 2:282

"Be wary" is a translation of the verb form of *taqwa*, with *taqwa* itself tracing back, as Ayatullah Khomeini explains, to a root meaning shield, such that being wary is "a kind of defense and shielding"[10], guarding the soul against whatever goes against what pleases God. Wariness grows from "the fear and awe of God Almighty"[11]. That guarding is why wariness comes first and God's teaching follows. Wariness, he writes, "purifies the soul and connects it to the invisible sacred realm", and divine teaching follows, "for there is no niggardliness in the higher realms, which are bounteous by necessity"[12].

Chapter One found the signs everywhere and the fault in the receiver, and the same holds for the light. It surrounds us, though the guiding is God's to give. "The light is everywhere," the Sheikh says, and if a heart stays dark, it is because the heart shuts out the light. Receiving it asks for a change within us: the purity that wariness of God brings.

Knowledge of God is therefore a light given to a purified heart, and study cannot gather it. A knowledge given to the heart also travels differently. The knowledge of books passes from mind to mouth, through language, whereas the knowledge of the 'urafa' passes "from heart to heart", in the Sheikh's words. Receiving it directly from God is possible but difficult, so one usually has to start through someone else, and Chapter Seven describes that guide.

STORY: A THOUSAND DOORS OF KNOWLEDGE

We know how knowledge passes from one mind to another, and Sheikh Bahmanpour traces the route. The speaker has an image in mind, and the body turns it into speech. The speech travels through the listener's nervous system

[10]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 198.
[11]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 291.
[12]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

and raises an image in the listener's mind. Of knowledge passing from one heart to another we have no such experience. He then recalls a report from Imam ʿAli (as): when the Prophet ﷺ was on his deathbed, a thousand doors of knowledge opened to Imam ʿAli's heart, and from each door a thousand more. In the Sheikh's telling, this knowledge did not come through language. It passed from heart to heart, and it is the kind of knowledge the ʿurafa' have.

The path is purification

If the light is everywhere and the heart is closed, the path to knowing God is the opening of the heart. Two Arabic words mark the difference between this path and study. Knowledge learned at a university or a seminary comes through thought (*fikr*): we think, put things together, analyse, and find out. Knowledge of God comes through wayfaring (*suluk*), the path to purity.

Wayfaring has two parts, and the Sheikh names both: "You purify yourself and then wait for Allah to put the light in your heart." The light is not absent while the heart waits, and the waiting is the patience of a heart that has done its part and leaves the rest to God. The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah ties the light to the path in one line.

إِنَّ مَنِ ٱنْتَهَجَ بِكَ لَمُسْتَنِيرٌ

One who follows Your path is enlightened.[13]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The same prayer asks, in the line this book opened with, for the eyes of the heart to be lit until they reach the source of God's grandeur. Here the prayer names who receives that light: the one who follows God's path.

Following that path begins with the shariʿa. Its first step is to polish the soul by doing whatever the Prophet ﷺ has asked. Without this there is no maʿrifah. The Qur'an calls the believers to answer Allah and the Apostle when he summons them to what will give them life (Q 8:24). That life comes when a person follows the Prophet completely.

[13]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §88.

Practice depends on knowing what to practise, and this is where study comes in. ʻAllama Tabataba'i, in the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, gives study an early place. Once the traveller has set out with a sincere intention, he says the first essential step is knowledge of shariʻa rules learned from a jurist. The traveller puts that knowledge into practice and persists until conviction and gnosis (*maʻrifah*) grow by degrees, "for knowledge gives birth to action and action in turn brings knowledge"[14].

Ayatullah Khomeini caveats the prominent position of learning with a warning, writing that "a learning that does not bring faith with it is the greatest of veils". Yet the veil cannot be avoided, only passed through: "one has to approach a veil in order to tear it into shreds". He adds that the sciences are "seeds of (spiritual) experience". He allows that high stations can be reached without them, but calls this unusual[15]. Without the polishing of the soul, in the Sheikh's words, there is no maʻrifah. Study can serve purification, but it cannot replace it.

STORY: THE PHILOSOPHER AND THE ʻARIF

Murtada Mutahhari records a meeting between Ibn Sina and Abu Saʻid ibn Abi al-Khayr, the latter being one of the most famous of all the ʻurafa'. Abu Saʻid was preaching on the necessity of deeds, and on obedience and disobedience to God. Ibn Sina answered him with a quatrain (a poem of four lines). Wherever God's favour and grace are found, it ran, "Let the not-done be like the done, the done like the not-done." The verse leaned on God's forgiveness in place of deeds. Abu Saʻid replied at once with a quatrain of his own, which ends: "Do not rely on forgiveness, for never / Was the not-done like the done, the done like the not-done"[16]. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Ibn Sina later wrote to Abu Saʻid asking to learn from him. Mutahhari, who calls Ibn Sina "mainly a philosopher, not a mystic", notes that "especially towards the end of his life he developed mystic inclinations"[17].

Knowing by drawing near

What study cannot give comes to the ʻurafa' through purification. Their nearness to God comes as the veils of the heart are unravelled: an action and

[14] ʻAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 56.
[15] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.
[16] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 29.
[17] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.

a process that cannot be substituted by learning a definition. The knowing of the ‘urafa’ is as present to their souls as hunger is to the one who fasts. It comes as a light that God gives to a purified heart, and so it differs in kind from knowing about God.

Where, then, does an ordinary believer already stand on this path?

> **➤ TRY THIS**
>
> In prostration in the daily prayer, many of us say, “Glory belongs to my Lord, the Exalted, and Him do I praise.” ‘Allama Tabataba’i uses these words to show how knowledge follows action[18]. For one week, in one prayer each day, say them slowly, “believing it to be a fact”. Notice your own lowliness with your forehead on the ground, then the majesty of the One you are calling exalted. From “a very minor action, such as this dhikr said in prostration”, he says, a person comes to discover God’s absolute majesty[19].

[18] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 56–57.

[19] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 56–57.